

Online Virtual Simulations

The popularity of online virtual worlds like *Second Life* (www.secondlife.com) has opened up an unforeseen avenue for training. Increasingly, a large number of corporate businesses are harnessing this avenue to open shop online.

Second Life is a virtual world—a 3D space on the Internet totally created and evolved by its users. The inbuilt content creation tools let you make almost anything you can imagine, in real-time or in collaboration with others. *Second Life* uses Linden dollars, a form of currency, which can be bought with real-world money. The ability to design and resell 3D content, be it virtual land plots or digital art, etc., means you can build a real business entirely within *Second Life*.

Training?

Companies have already started harnessing *Second Life* to advertise their products and showcase their content on their individual islands there, but what could be done in the future is use *Second Life* as a training medium to impart skill-sets to a wide audience from varied geographic locations. Alternatively, companies could start using *Second Life* as a testing ground for employees—monitoring their selling or running of the business to see how they perform in the virtual world, before giving them a promotion that would see them doing the same in the real world.

Using *Second Life* as a lower-cost testing ground could see venture capitalists trying out new business ideas online instead of risking large sums of real money. Perhaps we're not too

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A scene from *Second Life*

far away from the day when senior management interviews would consist of a three-month tryout period in *Second Life*.

Feasibility

As of today, there are only a few pioneering companies leasing out their virtual land to conduct goal-specific training for corporate trainees. Not many companies in India are delving into the virtual world for a variety of reasons. Paramount among them is the prohibitive costs of high-speed Internet access, which is required when playing any online virtual simulation game. Currently, avatar training holds the most promise, but with time and “free” or cheaper broadband, who knows... Perhaps the time is ripe for the pioneers amongst you to invest in a “Second Life Employee Training Corporation.” ■

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